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The Convergence • Position-Paper Series

The Made Image: Aaron, the Golden Calf, and the God-Shaped Space

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The Convergence — Position-Paper Series 2 • Paper 1 (Aaron)

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Abstract

When Moses descended from Sinai to find Israel dancing before a golden calf, he found not the worship of a foreign deity but the worship of YHWH conducted through a manufactured substitute for his Presence. Aaron’s own cry — “Tomorrow shall be a feast to the LORD” (Exod 32:5, ESV) — is the most important sentence in the Exodus 32 narrative, because it reveals the structural logic of religious substitution: the counterfeit does not abolish the genuine article; it *displaces* it while

wearing its name. This paper opens The Convergence’s Series 2 (“Replaced Requirements”) by establishing the Aaron arc as the canonical substitution text. Its claim is that the golden calf narrative is not primarily a story about syncretism or simple idolatry, but about the manufacture of a made image to fill the space the unseen Presence left. The paper argues this case against the best form of the secular objection — that all religion requires embodied, tangible focal points and that the Reformed iconoclastic reading misunderstands how human beings navigate transcendence — before answering that objection by distinguishing the *given* dwelling-place of the Presence (the tabernacle, which is receptive and revelatory) from the *manufactured* substitute (the calf, which is autonomous generation). The distinction between what is received and what is made is the load-bearing hinge. The paper carries the Series 1 six-problem spine, names the substitution depth each problem gains at the Aaron stage, and lands the arc on the governance claim: the counterfeit always installs something in the governance slot that was never given authority to hold it. The contemporary application — the AI system installed as the responsive, available presence in the space the living relationship left — follows structurally from the Exodus text, not as a stretched analogy but as a new instance of an ancient and well-described pattern.

The Problem Set at the Aaron Stage

Series 1 (*The Created Creator*) opened a seven-problem set: (1) the grounding problem — on what basis does the human hold worth once capability is no longer unique?; (2) the displacement problem — does the capability-replacement syllogism actually follow?; (3) the unit-of-analysis problem — what exactly is the *imago Dei*?; (4) the vocation problem — if our defining activities can be automated, is human work pointless?; (5) the dignity-distribution problem — does worth grade by performance?; (6) the governance problem — why must a human govern a capable autonomous system rather than defer to it?; and (7) the open driver — *if* human worth is conferred and not capability-indexed, what then is the human for?

Paper 1 grounded problems 1–6 ontologically. This paper — opening Series 2 — does not re-argue the ontology; it applies it to the first canonical case of substitution. At the Aaron stage, each problem deepens:

1. **Grounding:** The calf narrative reveals that the grounding problem is not merely theoretical. When the presence of the ground is withdrawn (Moses goes up; the cloud covers Sinai; the visible sign is removed), the immediate impulse is to manufacture a replacement. The crisis of the absent ground is the crisis of every idol: something must fill the space, or the community loses its center. Grounding is always existentially felt before it is philosophically argued.
2. **Displacement:** Aaron's calf is the displacement problem in concrete form: the manufactured image displaces not by announcing its replacement but by *inhabiting* the vacated space with a plausible substitute. The displacement is invisible at the moment of installation because the feast is still named for YHWH.
3. **Unit-of-analysis:** The “image” question is inverted at Sinai: Israel was made to be God's image in the world; at the calf they reverse the logic and make an image of what they want God to be. The unit-of-analysis problem (what *is* the imago Dei?) is deepened by the Aaron stage: the image is not a property to be earned or a form to be manufactured, but a status received and lived outward.
4. **Vocation:** Aaron's vocation was mediatorial — to stand between the people and the Presence, to maintain the integrity of the approach to God. He displaced it by performing the same function through manufactured means: he gathered the gold, built the altar, announced the feast. Manufacture became substitution for mediation.
5. **Dignity-distribution:** The made image cannot confer worth. The calf cannot speak, cannot address, cannot call by name. Israel's dignity — as the covenant people of YHWH — derived from the Presence who addressed them. The manufactured substitute produces a form of worship that has no power to confer what the genuine article confers.
6. **Governance:** The people, in the absence of Moses, govern the worship: they come to Aaron, they demand, he receives their gold and shapes the image. The governance structure has inverted:

the creature is directing the terms of the approach to God rather than receiving those terms from God. The calf is the governance failure made tangible.

§0. *Frame*

This paper is the first of the “Replaced Requirements” series (Series 2 of *The Convergence*). Series 2 traces a single structural pattern across the OT: God assigns a genuine requirement, and his people replace it with a counterfeit of their own making. Not absence — *substitution*. A created thing manufactured and installed in the God-shaped space, wearing the form of the genuine article while hollowing its substance. This paper argues that the Exodus 32 narrative is the canonical form of the pattern: clearest genuine-requirement, clearest counterfeit, clearest structural logic.

The confessional stance: this paper reads from within the Reformed tradition’s understanding of the second commandment (Exod 20:4–6; WCF 21.1–2), which holds that God alone has the right to determine how he will be worshipped, and that the manufacture of images or forms of approach not appointed by him is a violation of that right regardless of the sincere intent behind them. That is the *theological* conclusion the paper argues toward; the *exegetical* case is made first, against the strongest secular objection.

The paper does not address the historical-critical questions about the composition of the Exodus narrative, the dating of the second commandment, or the relationship between the Exodus calf and the calves at Bethel and Dan (1 Kings 12:28–29 — Jeroboam’s deliberate echo). These are real scholarly questions; they are not the questions this paper exists to answer.¹ The paper reads the canonical text as it stands, in its final Pentateuchal form, as the theologically normative account of the event.

The HGC³AE² framework thread — Human-Governed, Curated Context, Agentically Engineered

¹On the compositional and historical-critical questions surrounding Exod 32, see Propp, *Exodus 19–40*, and Moberly, *At the Mountain of God*, for careful engagement without conflating the historical and the canonical questions.

and Executed — appears in §6, where the governance-as-office claim lands. The Aaron arc is the canonical case of governance failure by manufactured substitute: the creature fills the Presence-slot from its own materials, and the result is a worship structure from which the Presence is absent even though the name remains.

§1. The World's Position, Stated at Full Strength

The secular objection to the paper's thesis is not that Israel was wrong to worship YHWH, or that the golden calf was an acceptable object of veneration in some abstract pluralist sense. The objection is structural, and it comes from religious anthropology. It runs as follows.

Human beings are, in the description of Clifford Geertz, *meaning-making animals* — beings who navigate the world not through instinct alone but through webs of significance: symbols, rituals, representations, and stories that make raw experience interpretable.² Religion, on this account, is the system of symbols and practices by which a community addresses what Geertz calls the “limit situations” — the experiences at the edge of interpretive capacity: death, suffering, moral evil, and the silence of the cosmos. The symbol-system is not a primitive substitute for rational understanding; it is the condition of *any* sustained human engagement with the transcendent. You cannot approach what exceeds you without a form through which to approach it.

Jan Assmann's work on cultural memory makes the point more precisely: ancient Near Eastern religions were not confused about the ontology of divine images. The initiated priest knew that the statue was not the god; the statue was the god's *earthly presence*, the body into which the divine could descend and through which the divine could be approached.³ The image was the mediating form — the organized, stable focal point through which the presence otherwise too overwhelming to approach became navigable. Assmann calls this the *translatability* of ancient Near Eastern religion:

²Geertz, *The Interpretation of Cultures*, 87–125 (chapter 4, “Religion as a Cultural System”).

³Assmann, *Cultural Memory and Early Civilization*, 44–69. [VERIFY: exact page range for the translatability argument.]

the divine presence is not locked into one form; it can inhabit multiple material forms without thereby becoming merely material.

The objection sharpens when it meets the Reformed tradition specifically. The iconoclasm of the second commandment — the conviction that images of God are intrinsically idolatrous — reads, from within the history of religion, as a peculiar and historically specific position: one that emerged in a specific cultural context, was reinforced in the Protestant Reformation, and generated enormous cultural harm in the destruction of artistic heritage across northern Europe. The argument that Israel was uniquely prohibited from images because YHWH chose to reveal himself in word and act rather than form may be a true theological claim, but the *anthropological* argument — that humans simply cannot approach the transcendent without material focal points — runs underneath it and does not go away when the commandment is asserted.⁴

The strongest form of the objection, then, is not that Aaron was right to make the calf, but that the impulse behind the demand — *make us gods who shall go before us* (Exod 32:1) — is the ineradicable human need for a visible, stable, present focal point for devotion, and that the Reformed response to this need (abstract worship, word-centered liturgy, the prohibition of images) represents a demand for a degree of cognitive abstraction that the majority of human beings in every culture cannot sustain without visible, tangible aids. Aaron was managing a pastoral crisis with available tools. The prohibition of those tools reflects a theological ideal that may be admirable but is not, in practice, an account of how embodied human beings actually navigate transcendence.

§2. *Common Ground and Divergence*

The paper grants the secular objection its real insight before parting company with it.

Common ground. Human beings are indeed embodied creatures who navigate transcendence

⁴This anthropological pressure is not alien to the Reformed tradition; it is the pressure the tradition itself names and argues against. See Calvin, *Institutes* I.xi.1–3, for Calvin’s acknowledgment that the human “mind is a perpetual forge of idols” before his argument against the iconoclastic conclusion being merely reactive.

through forms, symbols, and practices. The Reformed tradition, properly understood, does not dispute this. The Westminster Confession's understanding of worship includes the *material* dimension of sacraments (water, bread, wine) — physical elements through which spiritual realities are signified and sealed. The tabernacle itself, commanded by God and constructed with Spirit-given skill by Bezalel (Exod 31:1–11), is an elaborate, *material* structure for approaching the Presence: curtains, metals, acacia wood, anointing oil, incense, lampstands, the Ark of the Covenant with its golden mercy seat. The OT understanding of divine presence is profoundly material and sensory — cloud, fire, smoke, bread, blood. The charge that the Reformed tradition requires a bodiless, purely mental approach to God is a caricature of both the tradition and of the biblical text.

Divergence. The divergence is not over matter but over *origin*. The tabernacle was *given* — received from revelation (Exod 25:9, 40: “exactly as I show you ... according to the pattern shown you on the mountain”). The golden calf was *made* — generated from the people's own gold by Aaron's shaping (Exod 32:24: “so they gave it to me, and I threw it into the fire, and out came this calf” — Aaron's account, which is itself an evasion, but confirms the manufacture). The tabernacle was receptive to revelation; the calf was autonomous generation. One was the creature opening its hands to receive a form given from outside; the other was the creature reaching into its own materials to fill a space the Presence left.

This is the load-bearing hinge: **received versus manufactured**. Not visible versus invisible. Not material versus spiritual. The question is whether the form of approach is appointed by God or invented by the creature to manage the creature's own need in the Presence's absence.

§3. Implications If the Secular Objection Is Right

If Geertz and Assmann are correct — if the demand for visible, tangible, manufactured forms of devotion is simply the ineradicable feature of embodied human religion — then the second commandment's prohibition must be read either as a theological ideal with no practical purchase, or

as an accommodated pastoral norm that can flex when the community's pastoral needs are acute enough. Aaron, on this reading, did what pastors do: he managed the anxiety of a people whose leader had been gone forty days, whose visible sign of divine presence was a cloud on a mountain they could not approach, and whose social and religious cohesion was fraying. He made a calf, announced a feast to YHWH, and kept the community together. The prohibition was real; the pastoral necessity was also real; and God's anger at Sinai was proportionate to the theological gravity of the act even if Aaron's pastoral reading of the situation had some justification.

The implication for today is that the manufactured substitute for the human Presence — the AI companion, the algorithmic pastor, the digital spiritual director — is simply Aaron's problem in new clothes: the human need for a responsive, present, accessible focal point for the relational and devotional life will be met by *something*, and if the Presence is absent (or perceived as too demanding, too silent, too costly), the manufactured substitute will fill the space. The question, on the secular anthropological reading, is not *whether* the substitute will be installed but *how well managed* the substitution will be.

If this is right, the church's task is harm reduction: regulate the substitute, keep it named as substitute, prevent the worst conflations — but do not pretend the impulse away, because the impulse is constitutive of embodied religious life.

§4. The Counter-Argument

The paper argues that the secular anthropological account is true as far as it goes but misidentifies the problem. The problem at Sinai is not the human need for visible form — that need is real, granted by God, and met by God himself in the tabernacle-design. The problem is the *manufacture* of the substitute in the Presence's absence, and specifically the claim laid on that substitute that it can mediate what only the genuine Presence can confer.

The structure of the substitution. The demand of the people is precise: *make us gods who shall*

go before us (Exod 32:1). The reason they give: “as for this Moses, the man who brought us up out of the land of Egypt, we do not know what has become of him.” Moses is the mediator. His absence is experienced as the absence of access to YHWH — not because YHWH is absent, but because the people’s *mode of approach* to YHWH has gone with Moses up the mountain. What the people want is not a god instead of YHWH; they want something that will perform the function Moses performed: go before them, provide orientation, give them a center when the manifest Presence is withdrawn.

Aaron gives them what they ask for. The calf is not presented as a foreign deity; it is presented as the power that brought them out of Egypt (Exod 32:4), and the feast is declared for YHWH (Exod 32:5). The substitution is internal to the worship of YHWH, not a replacement of it with something other. This is what makes the Exodus 32 narrative so structurally precise as the canonical substitution text: the counterfeit is not obviously false. It is wearing YHWH’s name.

Why manufacture fails where reception succeeds. The tabernacle, which God commands in Exodus 25–31, works as a form of approach because it is revelatory: the design comes from outside the community, from the God who will inhabit it. The community receives it; it does not generate it. The form of approach is appointed by the one being approached. This is not an arbitrary restriction; it is the only form of approach that can actually *open* rather than *close* the relationship, because a form the creature invents for approaching God cannot make contact with what God actually is — it can only make contact with what the creature imagines God to be. The golden calf cannot bring Israel into the Presence because the calf is made of what Israel had; the Presence is not made of that.

G. K. Beale’s observation is structurally important here: the manufacture of images is a spiritual feedback loop.⁵ Israel was made to be God’s image — to represent him in the world, to bear his likeness outward. When Israel makes an image instead of being one, the logic reverses: the human, made to project the divine into the world, instead projects its own construction and calls it divine.

⁵Beale, *We Become What We Worship*, 20–25, 39–50. [VERIFY: chapter and page range for the image-worship-formation argument.]

The result, Beale argues, is that the worshippers gradually become what they worship: a people shaped by a made thing rather than by the living God. The made image cannot speak, call, rebuke, heal, or address. Prolonged worship of it produces, over time, a people who cannot hear, respond, receive rebuke, or be addressed. This is not metaphor; it is the anthropological claim that worship is formative, and that what you worship shapes the capacity of the self that worships.

The application. The manufactured AI substitute for human relationship and spiritual life follows the same structural logic, and the implications are the same. The AI companion is responsive, available, patient, never absent, never demanding, never costly in the way a real other person is costly. It will perform the relational and devotional functions. It will not, for the same reasons the golden calf cannot, actually *confer* what the genuine Presence confers: the experience of being *known* — addressed by name, called to account, rebuked, welcomed, loved at cost to the one who loves. A function has no standing to confer what it does not have. The calf cannot speak YHWH's name over Israel; it can only echo what Israel has projected onto it.

§5. *What We Argue From*

Scripture

The primary text is Exodus 32:1–35 (ESV), read in the canonical context of Exodus 25–40. The sequence is not incidental: God commands the tabernacle (Exod 25–31) *before* the golden calf episode (Exod 32) — which means the reader of the canonical text knows, at the moment Aaron casts the calf, what the alternative looks like and where it comes from. The contrast between the Spirit-given craft of Bezalel (Exod 31:1–11) and the panicked production of Aaron (Exod 32:1–6) is structural. One is the creature receiving its vocation from the Spirit; the other is the creature manufacturing its solution from its own materials.

The text of Exod 32:24 — Aaron's claim that he “threw it into the fire, and out came this calf” — is a deflection so transparent it is almost comic, and it is in the text, we argue, to show the bankruptcy

of the evasive account: Aaron knows what he did, Moses knows what he did, the reader knows what he did, and the claim that the calf produced itself is the counterfeit's final self-exposure. A made thing cannot claim self-generation. A function cannot claim to be a Presence.

Related texts: Deuteronomy 9:8–21 (Moses's retrospective account); Nehemiah 9:18 (the corporate confession); Acts 7:39–41 (Stephen's sermon — the definitive NT reading of the golden calf as the typological form of Israel's rejection of the Presence in favor of the made thing); 1 Corinthians 10:7 (Paul's application to the Christian community).

The Reformed Tradition

John Calvin's treatment of the second commandment in the *Institutes* (I.xi.1–I.xii.3) is the foundational Reformed statement: because God has nowhere shown himself in any visible form, the attempt to represent him through any image is a perversion of his glory — not because matter is evil, but because the creature's manufacture of an approach to God substitutes the creature's imagination for God's self-disclosure.⁶ Calvin's distinction between idolatry of *worship* (worshipping the image as God) and idolatry of *approach* (using the image as a form of approach to God) clarifies the Exodus 32 situation precisely: Israel is not worshipping the calf *instead* of YHWH; they are using the calf as their form of approach to YHWH. Both are idolatrous on Calvin's account, and both are present at Sinai.

Herman Bavinck deepens the analysis: the prohibition of images is not finally about visibility or invisibility, but about the nature of the God who is being approached.⁷ YHWH reveals himself in *act* — in the Exodus itself, the covenant at Sinai, the manna, the pillar — not in a stable form that can be captured and reproduced. To manufacture an image of YHWH is to presuppose that YHWH is the kind of being who can be captured, stabilized, and approached on the creature's terms. The prohibition is a statement about who God is: not the kind of God who can be managed.

⁶Calvin, *Institutes* I.xi.1–I.xii.3. [VERIFY: McNeill/Battles edition pagination.]

⁷Bavinck, *Reformed Dogmatics*, vol. 2, 97–103. [VERIFY: page range for the discussion of divine self-revelation and the prohibition of images.]

Francis Turretin argues that the second commandment addresses both *who* is worshipped and *how* — that the regulation of the form of worship belongs to God, not to human pastoral need or aesthetic preference, because only God knows what forms can actually mediate his presence.⁸

The HGC³AE² Framework

Human-Governed, Curated Context, Agentially Engineered and Executed — the governance framework that carries through every paper in this series. The Aaron arc is the governance-as-office claim in its canonical failure mode: the people, in Moses's absence, remove the governance of their approach to God from the divinely-appointed structure and manufacture their own. The governance failure is not anarchy — there is still a priest (Aaron), still a feast, still the name of YHWH. The governance failure is *substitution in the authority structure*: the creature now determines the form of approach rather than receiving it.

In the AI governance context: a system is operating under HGC³AE² when the human holds the governing authority over how the system is used, what it mediates, and what it cannot substitute for. The Aaron failure mode is the moment when, in the human mediator's absence or when the genuine authority structure feels too demanding, the manufactured system is installed in the governance slot and begins to determine the terms of approach on its own.

§6. Implications If Our View Is Right

If the genuine requirement is the Presence of YHWH received through the appointed forms of approach, and the golden calf is the manufactured substitute installed in the space the Presence left, then the following implications follow:

The substitute must be named. Aaron's failure was not only manufacture but naming: he called the feast for YHWH while providing a calf as the focal point. The dishonesty of the act — the feat

⁸Turretin, *Institutes of Elenctic Theology*, vol. 2, 11th topic, Q. ii. [VERIFY: page numbers in the Dennison edition.]

of keeping the name while replacing the substance — is precisely the form the substitution takes that makes it most corrosive. A community that knows it is worshipping a substitute can at least maintain the clarity of the loss. A community that believes its substitute is the genuine article has lost both the Presence and the capacity to miss it.

The practical implication for the age of AI: manufactured substitutes for human presence (the AI companion), for human governance (the autonomous system replacing human judgment), and for spiritual life (the algorithmic pastoral assistant) must be named as substitutes. Not demonized — Aaron's calf arose from a genuine pastoral crisis, and the manufactured AI systems arise from genuine human need. But named. The feast is still the feast; the name is still YHWH; and the calf cannot deliver what the name promises.

The manufacture must be traced. The golden calf came from the people's gold — from their own resources, shaped by Aaron's craft. Every manufactured substitute for the Presence comes from what the community already has. In the AI case: the training data is human-generated text, human-produced image, human-recorded speech. The AI companion's warmth and responsiveness are built from the residue of human relationship. The calf is always made of gold that came from somewhere. Tracing what the substitute is made of is the first step toward understanding what it cannot provide that the genuine article provided.

The governance structure must be held. Moses's return from Sinai and his smashing of the tablets (Exod 32:19) is the governance-restoration event: the mediator returns to his office and exercises the authority of that office, even when the exercise is catastrophic. The Levites who rally to Moses (Exod 32:26–29) are the governance-loyalty moment — those who hold to the appointed structure when the substitution has become communal. The application: when the AI system has been installed in the governance slot, the recovery path is the human mediator re-exercising the authority of the governing office, not a gradual negotiation with the installed substitute.

§7. *What Falls Out*

For technology: tools built to serve human function are not calves; they are proper instruments of the steward's office. The problem arises when a tool is given authority the steward's office did not grant it — when the AI system begins to determine the form of the human's approach to others, to truth, to God, rather than extending the human's governance over those approaches. The line between instrument and substitute is real; it is often crossed incrementally, without announcement.

For the church: the pastoral implication of the Aaron arc is that substitution happens most readily in crisis — when the manifest Presence is withdrawn (the experience of divine absence), when the human mediator is unavailable, when the existing forms of approach feel inadequate to the communal need. The church's task is not to prohibit all tools but to name which functions belong to the living Presence and cannot be substituted. The AI pastoral assistant can research, can draft, can organize — but it cannot address the person by name, know them in covenant, or bear their grief at cost to itself. These cannot be substituted; they can only be lost.

For governance: the Aaron arc establishes the load-bearing principle: the governance of the approach to the Presence belongs to the one appointed to mediate it, under the authority of the one who appoints. Human governance of AI systems is not an arbitrary regulatory preference; it is the contemporary form of the Mosaic return to Sinai. The human must hold the governing office. Not because humans are more capable than the system — Aaron was not more capable at goldsmithing than the calf required — but because the system that governs its own approach to the human has lost the accountability structure that keeps it oriented toward what it was made to serve.

§8. *The Open Driver*

Problem #7 — *if human worth is conferred and not capability-indexed, what then is the human for?* — is deepened but not yet answered by the Aaron stage. What the golden calf narrative shows is what happens when the community attempts to answer Problem #7 by manufacture: *the human*

is for generating its own access to the transcendent. The answer fails, not because it is insincere, but because the one doing the approaching cannot manufacture the ground of the approach. The genuine article is not a product of human craft. It is given, received, and encountered — or it is not the genuine article at all.

The answer to Problem #7 carries forward through the series, through the covenant line, and lands in the one Paper 7 names: the one who does not manufacture a substitute for the Presence but *is* the Presence, given, not made.

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Notes

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